

for you to use. These calculators make it easy to plug in different interest rates, monthly payment amounts, and so forth to get the most accurate numbers for your situation.

3. Running these scenarios is helpful to get your mind churning on key actions you can take over specific time periods. For example, finding ways to increase your income to increase your investment contributions or to accelerate paying down your debt.

CLEVER GIRL INVESTOR: MEET CINDY E. ZUNIGA

Cindy is a commercial litigation attorney and the founder of Zero-Based Budget Coaching LLC (zero-basedbudget.com), where she provides personal finance coaching services to individuals and couples and speaks to audiences about money. She graduated from law school in June 2015 and landed her dream job at a prestigious law firm in New York City, but she had \$215,000 of student loan debt from law school to contend with. She decided to immerse herself in the world of personal finance and focused on creating a concrete plan to pay off her debt. Less than five years later, she did just that, becoming debt-free in December 2019. She leveraged her Instagram account @zerobasedbudget to document her journey to becoming debt free and now uses it to share financial tidbits to help women simplify personal finance concepts. Her mission now is to spread the message of financial literacy to women, particularly to women of color like herself.

Q. Over the last few years you've been focused on paying off your student loans that totaled \$215,000; however, you still managed to invest at the same time. What approach did you take in order to do both of these things strategically?

A. I did two things. First, I invested in the 401(k) plan offered by my employer. At first, I noticed the difference in my paycheck, but after a month or two I got used to it. It honestly felt like effortless investing. I also opened an account with Betterment, a robo-advisor. I consider myself to be a passive investor and was honestly still very new to investing, so I knew that a robo-advisor would be the best fit for me. I answered a few questions about my goals and risk tolerance and was set up with specific investments.